

One discipline governs agent work from intent to release

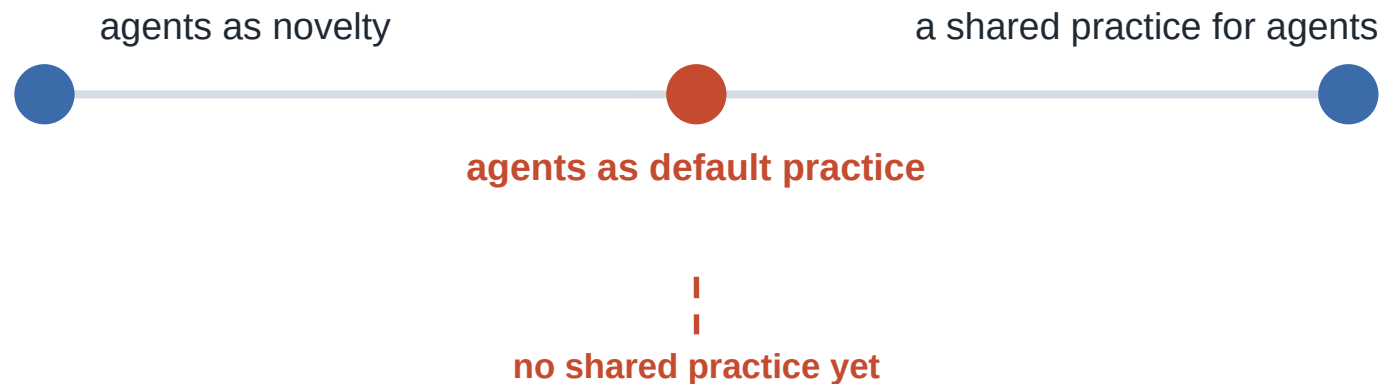
An evaluation briefing for engineering leaders whose teams build
with AI agents



September 2026

2 Agents now write most production code

- Most professional developers ship agent-written code every day
- The output is locally good and globally inconsistent
- The document disciplines human teams built never reached the agents
- Every practice era gets its equivalent of test-driven development



how agent-written code became the default before any discipline caught up

3 Agent code drifts without a shared practice



Drift

specs and code
diverge between
sessions



Contradiction

a design ignores an
earlier decision

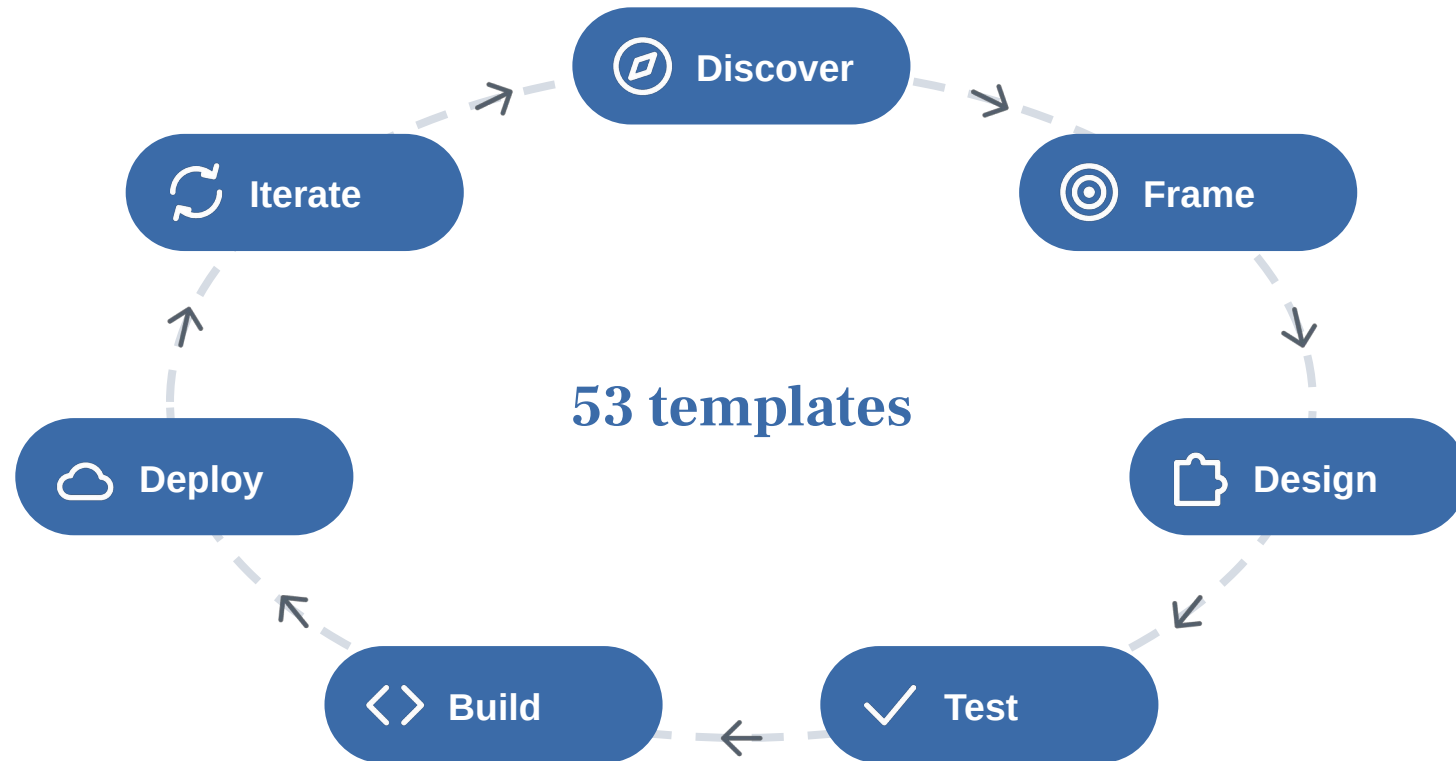


Cold start

every session starts
from zero

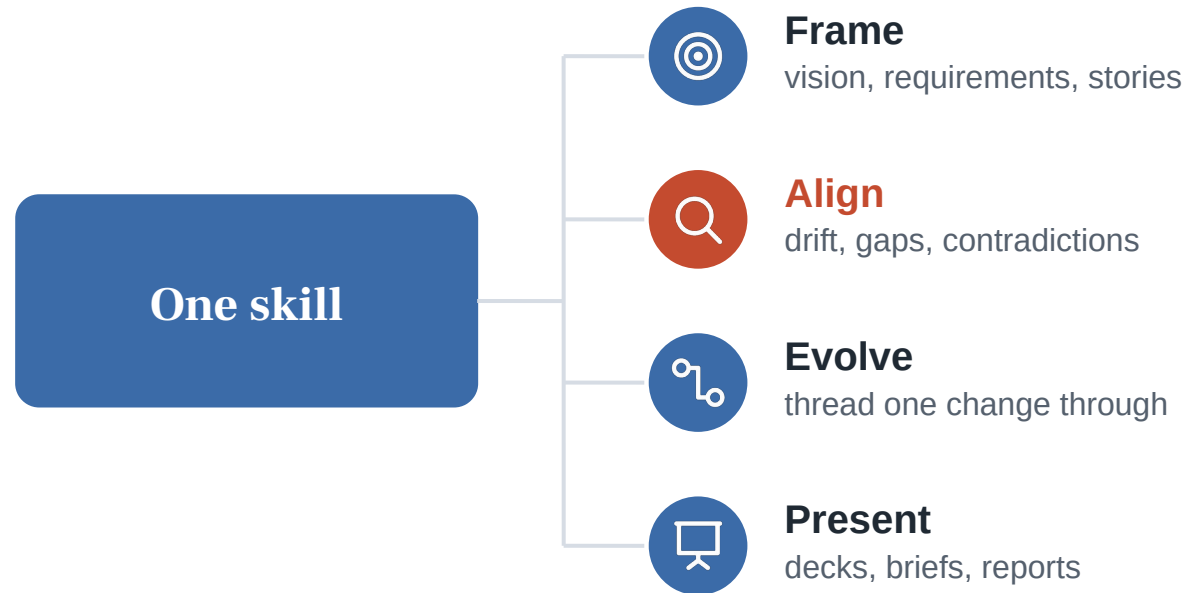
- Specs, designs, and tests fall out of sync because nobody walks them between sessions
- A feature ships whose design contradicts a decision recorded months earlier
- Each new conversation re-improvises the workflow, so reviews get skipped

4 HELIX is the shared practice, built from templates

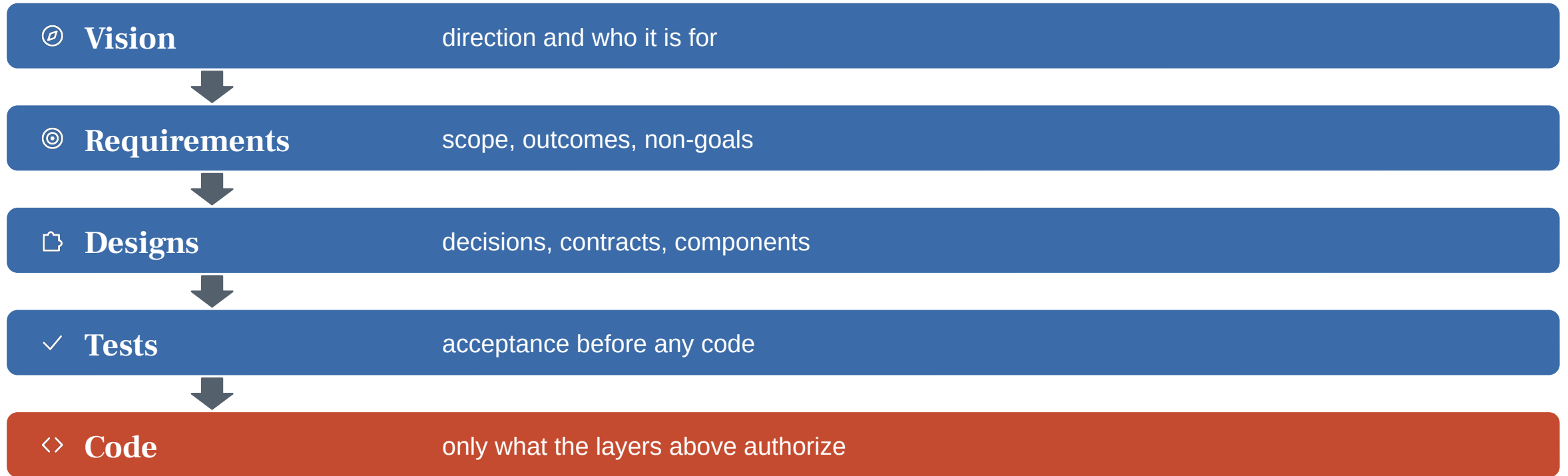


5 One skill reads the templates and routes each request

- A single skill installs on the agent runtime and reads the same documents
- It routes each request to one of twenty-one modes
- Alignment is the required mode; it finds drift and hands back a plan
- The skill body is portable: no runtime commands, so it loads on any host



6 Each template layer governs the layer below



a change enters at the top layer it touches and flows down

7 Concerns and gates carry control across layers



Without layered control

Each agent re-decides framework, auth, and test approach per task

Drift shows up in review or in production

A claim of done goes unchecked



With layered control



The team selects a concern once and its practices propagate down



Gates stop work moving down a layer



Every claim cites evidence a validator can check

Verdict: the rules live in the layers, not in a prompt

8 Those same layers produce the documents sponsors read



Status report

for sponsors and clients, from the iteration plan, with evidence per claim



Deck or brief

for executives and customers, from any governed document set, every number sourced



Release notes

for users and support, from the deploy documents

9 One gate caught five affected documents before coding

- A team asked its agent to add OAuth login
- The alignment check found 3 affected feature specs and 2 affected designs
- It flagged 1 recorded decision that conflicted with the OAuth pattern
- It listed 4 missing user stories and 1 test plan to revise



3 specs

affected by the
change



1 decision

in conflict with
OAuth



4 stories

missing and
now listed



1 test plan

to revise first

People decide and agents draft at every gate



People hold



What to build and which decision stands



Approval that turns a draft into authority



When the work is complete



How much runs unasked, a three-position dial



Agents hold

Drafting every document in its template

Checking each draft against the layer above

Surfacing drift, contradictions, and gaps

Stopping at the triggers and handing judgment back

Verdict: the hand-offs have owners and rules, never an implied one

11 Pilot HELIX for one quarter and count what gates catch

Pilot HELIX for one quarter and count what gates catch

	Step	Owner	Date
	Pick one active project with an agent already in the loop, by the end of this week		
	Adopt the templates and run one alignment check on its documents in the first sprint		
	Review the findings together after four weeks against the bar of under 3 findings per check		

Without a trial the practice stays improvised and drift keeps surfacing in review

Sources

Id	Claim or figure	Governing artifact and section
S1	A methodology and artifact catalog for AI-assisted teams: templates plus one skill	docs/helix/00-discover/product-vision.md#mission-statement
S2	AI-assisted development went from novelty to default; most developers ship AI-touched code daily	docs/helix/00-discover/product-vision.md#why-now
S3	Three failure modes: artifact drift, inconsistent agent behavior, lossy session boundaries	docs/helix/01-frame/prd.md#problem
S4	Templates for 53 artifact types plus a single routing skill; no CLI, tracker, or execution loop	docs/helix/01-frame/prd.md#summary
S5	The seven activities, the artifact loop, and the authority hierarchy	workflows/README.md#activities, workflows/README.md#authority-hierarchy, workflows/artifact-hierarchy.md
S6	Twenty-one routed modes in the routing table; alignment is the required mode	skills/helix/SKILL.md#routing-rules, docs/helix/01-frame/prd.md#goals

Sources (continued)

Id	Claim or figure	Governing artifact and section
S7	Four-step contract: write the brief, check alignment, plan the work, run it	docs/helix/01-frame/prd.md#core-workflow-contract
S8	OAuth example: three specs and two designs affected, one decision in conflict, four stories missing	docs/helix/00-discover/product-vision.md#user-experience
S9	Concerns propagate practices downstream; the project's active concerns and slots; 50 concerns in the library	workflows/README.md#cross-cutting-context, docs/helix/01-frame/concerns.md, workflows/concerns
S10	Seven principles, from spec is the contract to deliverable over machinery, with tension resolution	workflows/principles.md#principles, docs/helix/01-frame/principles.md
S11	Artifact honesty: phantom claims block; verification evidence comes from the running system	docs/helix/01-frame/features/FEAT-016-artifact-honesty.md, workflows/concerns/verification/practices.md
S12	Tests cite the criterion they cover; quality floors never slide back	docs/helix/02-design/adr/ADR-009-acceptance-criteria-ownership.md, workflows/ratchets.md

Sources (continued)

Id	Claim or figure	Governing artifact and section
S13	Non-goals: no CLI, tracker, queue, or engine; no imposed technology; judgment stays with people	docs/helix/01-frame/prd.md#non-goals
S14	Six install surfaces: DDx, Claude Code, Codex, Copilot, Databricks Genie, Grok Build	docs/helix/01-frame/features/FEAT-013-runtime-install-coverage.md, docs/install/README.md
S15	Autonomy is a three-position spectrum with a hard-stop floor at every level	docs/helix/02-design/adr/ADR-003-autonomy-spectrum.md
S16	Roadmap, iteration plan, status report; a client cut may subset but never contradict	docs/helix/01-frame/features/FEAT-017-iteration-documentation.md
S17	Deliverables projected from governed artifacts, every number sourced, gated and inspected	workflows/modes/present.md, workflows/activities/06-iterate/artifacts/deliverable/meta.yml
S18	Targets: < 3 findings per run; 3 runtimes in 12 months; 50+ repos in 18 months	docs/helix/00-discover/product-vision.md#success-definition, docs/helix/01-frame/prd.md#success-metrics

Sources (continued)

Id	Claim or figure	Governing artifact and section
S19	Layers are the control: each layer governs the next; a change enters at the top layer it affects; rules live in a layer, not a prompt	workflows/principles.md#layers-are-the-control
S20	The hierarchy as control loop: authority flows down, concerns cross layers, gates sit between layers, humans hold the hand-offs	workflows/artifact-hierarchy.md#the-hierarchy-is-the-control-loop
S21	Humans decide, agents draft: people own intent, judgment, approval; agents own drafting, checking, surfacing, recording; every hand-off has an owner and a rule	workflows/principles.md#humans-decide-agents-draft
S22	Hand-off table: approval, autonomy level, stop triggers, escalation, surfaced judgment, and the rule behind each	workflows/README.md#human-ai-collaboration , docs/helix/00-discover/product-vision.md#key-value-propositions